

**DEATH AND THE DIMENSIONS OF HONOUR IN BARCLAYS AYAKOROMA'S
A MATTER OF HONOUR AND JOHN SUOFE'S THE LAST RITES**

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ABSTRACT

This paper is an attempt to analyze death and its different dimensions of honour in Izon land. The basic problem of this study concerns the fact that, while much has been written about death in African Literature, the specifics “dialectics of burial and territoriality” (disputes over where a corpse should be buried to maintain family/community pride) and extravagant funerary ceremonies has not been given enough attention in Nigerian drama. The dramatic works selected for examination here are; A Matter of Honour by Barclays Ayakoroma's and The Last Rites by John Suofe. The research work examines the cultural, social and specifically, Izon (Niger Delta) perspective on death and dignity. The theoretical framework is anchored both on the Post-colonial Theory whose focus is on how traditional Izon/African values (identity, honour, community, burial rite's) clash with modern realities or external influences, and how the Plays reclaim cultural narratives, and African Cultural Theory, which is often used in African drama, focusing on the intersection of death, ritual, and communal harmony, rather than just individual loss. The study adopts the qualitative research design, while methodology used is textual analysis. The findings of the research reveal the invaluable role of burial as the ultimate expression of family/communal Honour to the dead. Furthermore, this study has unveiled issues of death as a site of conflict, territorial consciousness, and extravagant funerary ceremonies. This study recommends the re-evaluation of cultural traditions on burial and honour, such as communities/families re-examining rigid traditions regarding burial rites that privilege paternal heritage over the actual place of residence (maternal or chosen land) as these often lead to avoidable conflicts and also understanding funeral practices as political strategy as contribution to knowledge.

Keywords: Death, Dimensions, Honour, A Matter of Honour and The Last Rites.

Introduction:

Death and Burial are significant aspects of human existence in our societies. Death is universal and inevitable biological phenomenon that affects all organisms. As a global phenomenon, it is characterized by varying causes, significant geographical disparities, and profound cultural and philosophical significance across different societies. According to Binebai, (2016, p. 102), “death is the end of life and the very active beginning of a man's past on cessation of life. Death is the last of the four rites of passage in traditional African Society. The others are ritual of birth, puberty and initiation as well as marriage”. Death, being an inevitable phenomenon, the fact remains that when humans die, an honour which is identified as the last respect is accorded the dead. Death may be individual or collective. The subject of death in our societies have caused many crisis and tribulations both in our local societies, nation and even at the international scene. However, in core traditional African society from the prehistoric times, death leads to burial rites and in burial, there is either the family unity or communal interest and pride. Death and burial are therefore, central to Honour in traditional African Society from the prehistoric

times.

It is a clear fact in contemporary time, corpses have been dragged by either two communities or two or more family units within a community particularly in the Niger Delta. Thus, in the struggle to gain control of the dead, some individuals are either killed in the process or sustain injuries. More worrisome, is the extravagant burial ceremonies organized to honour the dead, while, in the life time of the now so deceased, penury and poverty where the likely guests of these people. The ideal situation would have been expending extravagantly on these seeming dead while they were alive. But no! What does society get? Society gets a gift of senseless conflicts and elaborate shows in the name of paying the last rites (honour), thus, failing to comprehend "Honour" as traditionally defined. A realistic definition of honour must therefore take into consideration an evaluation of the generating emotion in order to give it credibility and significance. This will enable it to create for its beneficiary a feeling of social and spiritual fulfillment, which should translate into a collective accomplishment.

The determinants of honour are to a large extent external. It is bestowed and then earned. In the society of the Plays, the virtues of honour and integrity are largely assessed by the degree to which man is able to function with respect to his value system. But the various communities are determined to define honour along lines that are at variance with traditionally accepted guidelines. And so the fundamental principle of honour, hinged on strong moral inclinations are a preservation and maintenance of the tenets of integrity, continue to elude the people, because, when 'honour' and pride are stretched beyond socially accepted limits, like what happens in the two Plays, it becomes a demand. A resolution of the attendant conflict is what the playwrights put in place at the end of the play. For all these to happen, both Ayakoroma and Suofe goes at length to present to us various interpretations of honour which constitute the most sought after property in *A Matter of Honour* and *The Last Rites*. Each of the playwrights explore their own idea of a true Honour that can be accorded the dead.

Statement of the problem

Several African playwrights/literary scholars such as Wole Soyinka in his play; *Death and the King's Horseman*, Kofi Awoonor in his poem (*Had Death Not Had Me In Tears*), John Mbiti in his definition of the African concept of the "afterlife". Chinua Achebe, who is father of African literature whose Novels often portray death as a community event and spiritual passage, Razak Malik, with his dirges, Ogundare, who perceives death from traditional African view as a passage and transformation in his poems, and of course, Bennedict Binebai in his article titled; *Dialectics of burial and territoriality* had written much about in African Literature, yet, the specifics; Dialectics of burial and territoriality (disputes over where a corpse should be buried to maintain family/community pride), extravagant funerary ceremonies, ritual/rites comparison, critique of violence in tradition and contextualization of honour within Izon world has not received sufficient scholarly attention. The two selected plays are scarcely exposed to the aforementioned research depths for academic purposes. It is against this backdrop that, the basic problem of this study concerns the dearth of rigorous academic research of the selected plays. Thus, this study proves to fill that gap.

Aim and objectives of the study

The aim of this research is to comparatively analyze the representation of death and the varied dimensions of honour in the selected plays studied here; and to reviewing the Izon worldview of honouring the dead (specifically the conflict between communal, traditional, and individual values in Barclays Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour* and extravagant funerary ceremonies in John Suofe's *The Last Rites*.

The specific objective of this study is to examine how the selected plays; *A Matter of Honour* and *The Last Rites*, explore death as a focal point for negotiating cultural honour, community identity, familial obligation, and economic frugality in contemporary African society,

Significance of the study

This research is significant in two levels, theory and practice. At the level of theory, this study has successfully used both the Postcolonial and African Cultural perspectives in the analysis of the work, while, at the level of practice, this study provides additional knowledge for scholars in traditional cultural and literary studies.

Scope of the study

The scope of this study has to do with the textual analysis of the selected dramatic plays studied here in relation to the topic with a view to unraveling the cultural nuances in the Izon cosmos as a product of Africa literature.

Methodology

Research design

This study adopts the qualitative analysis research design on the selected dramatic works of African playwrights.

Population of the study:

The population of this study consists of two (2) selected African plays. They are; *A Matter of Honour* by Barclays Ayakoroma and *The Last Rites* by John Suofe.

Sampling and Sampling technique

This study chooses two (2) plays that constitute the population of the study. The purposive sampling technique was used to sample these plays, they possess similar thematic contents In their plots.

Nature/Sources of data

Data for this study were collected from primary and secondary sources. The primary source materials are; the African traditional religion whose influence came from the Izon worldview about burial customs/rites. While the secondary sources are the original source texts, textbooks, journals, thesis, reports, novels, poems, play texts, and internet sources.

Method of data collection

Data was drawn through the process of textual analysis of the two selected plays. The researcher was faced with the task of reading the plays with recourse to examining the cultural, social and specifically, Izon (Niger Delta) perspectives on death and dignity. This study selected two(2) plays that constitute the population of the study.

Method of data analysis

This study adopts the method of textual analysis of the selected plays with a view to arriving at the aim and objective of the study.

Validity/Reliability of instruments

The instruments employed for data collection include readings, evaluation, comprehension of texts, journals and the plays under study. The validity of the data collection instruments was determined through simple conventional means of observation and in-depth analysis of the selected texts.

Theoretical Framework

It would be recalled that, a major objective of this study is to examine how the selected plays; *A Matter of Honour* and *The Last Rites*, explore death as a focal point for negotiating cultural honour, community identity, familial obligation and economic frugality in contemporary African society. Against this backdrop, the theoretical frameworks adopted for this study are;

1) Postcolonial theory

This theory examines cultural traditions/African worldview, thus focusing on how traditional Izon/African values such as identity, honour, community, burial rites clash with modern realities or external influences, and how the plays reclaim cultural narratives.

Application to the study

Based on the research topic; *Death and the Dimensions of Honour in Barclays Ayakoroma's A Matter of Honour and John Suofe's The Last Rites*, whose works addresses the conflict between traditional cultural practices regarding burial, community pride, and extravagant funerary ceremonies with the view to paying the last respect or honouring the dead, and modern peaceful or practical consideration. Against this background, both Ayakoroma and Suofe's plays need a reference here to align with the adopted theory so as to foreground the appropriateness of its application. For example; Ayakoroma in his play, *A Matter of Honour* deals with the following problems;

1. Dispute over corpse ownership

Ayakoroma in this play made us understand that, the central issue is the struggle over rights of possession of a corpse between different parties, often paternal and maternal communities in the Niger Delta which leads to intense conflict and the threat of violence. At Amabiri, which is the birth place and fatherland of Oweibi, during a marriage function, a news came from Egberi, (a drunkard) that Oweibi their son, who was living in Angiama (his motherland) has died. So based on ancient Izon tradition supporting patriarchy, and therefore, necessitates all dead whether man or woman outside their fatherland to be buried at Amabiri. Meanwhile, Angiama (Motherland) which Oweibi lived and died also insists on burying him there, citing strong maternal care for him. Therefore, where Oweibi should be buried becomes a dispute between the communities of Amabiri and Angiama.

2. Misplaced conception of "Honour" and "pride".

The research tackles the pathological defense of tradition where Communities, such as Amabiri in Ayakoroma's play, *A Matter of Honour* prioritizes the rigid, patriarchal or traditional way of burying the dead as a matter of pride, even at the cost of peace, whereas, in John Suofe's *The Last Rites*, honour and pride seemed also misplaced in the name of burying the dead. In the play, the author challenged the wasteful financial expenses on the dead in the name of paying the last rites. For him, it would have been better, such honour be accorded at when the person is alive. This leads us to the question; do the dead hear or see anything? Therefore, all that extravagant funerary ceremonies performed becomes a waste and irrational. Characters who represent this fate in the play are; Olotu, and the pretended dead father of Kosu-owe, Izon-owe.

3. There is also the conflict between tradition and modernity in Barclays, *A Matter of Honour*, the specific problem that causes the conflict is; adhering to the rigid, sometimes "brainless" or illogical customs which the post-colonial theory emphasizes.

2. African Cultural Theory

This theory is often used in analyzing African drama, with emphasis on the intersection of death, ritual and communal harmony, rather than just individual loss.

Application to the study:

For instance, in Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour*, the issues at the centre of the conflict are death, burial, pride and nationalism. The play chastises death and puts forward burial of the dead as the major subject of disagreement that sets the dramatic action rolling until it got to its denouement. The conflict is based on the death of Oweibi who is to be buried where he died. Amabiri is his birthplace, (his fatherland) but, all through his life, Oweibi lived and died at Angiama, his motherland. But according to the ancient Izon culture and tradition, a man and a woman, whether they die in their fatherland or outside their fatherland or even outside both father and mother lands within and outside their environment, are brought back to their fatherland for burial. It is therefore, a well-built tradition that Izens that die are buried in their fatherland.

The value placed on the tradition is so strong that it has the face of pride, identity and the force of nationalism. Thus, a community in Izonland draws honour, pride and nationalism in burying its own dead people. The same honour affects also the person buried. The only reason behind this is a "matter of honour". This is to secure family, community ethics and identity. Thus, in this drama, death becomes a very significant and obligatory defining influence and factor of territoriality. Territoriality as a term means possessive feeling over places. It is about claim over a defined territory and essentially about how people appropriate space to communicate ownership of area.

So, also in John Suofe's *The Last Rites*; the focal point treated there is that of death. However, in his perception of the concept of death and dignity, the playwright frowns at the elaborate funerary ceremonies thrown to the dead who does not know or see what happens behind him. All these are done in the name of paying the last rites. Thus, one may ask; why can't players exhibit this "Honour" called the last rite at when these people were alive, so that they can feel, see and enjoy it?

Thus riding on the crest of communal clashes over corpse burial, according honour and pride, conflicting traditions, death and territoriality, misplaced conception of honour, and of course, extravagant funerary ceremonies in the Izon worldview which this paper explores, it can be boldly said that, the application of both the Post-colonial and African Cultural theories to this work is appropriate.

Results and Discussions

Plot/Structure development of *A Matter of Honour* by Barclays Ayakoroma.

As plot structure formulas vary, here in this analysis, Freytag's concept of dramatic structure is what is used.

Exposition

The play; *A Matter of Honour* by Barclays Ayakoroma is set in the 19th century Nigeria, specifically in the Niger Delta region with high stakes of conflicts and protests. It is structured in seven movements. The plot is scattered around between Amabiri and Angiama. However, it formally opens with the news of the death of Oweibi who was born in Amabiri (fatherland) but lived and died in Angiama (motherland). This initial situation highlights the traditional Izon custom that, a person must be buried in their paternal home.

Dramatic conflict and rising action

The play attains its crisis when Oweibi who was living in Angiama dies, but Amabiri, his birthplace/fatherland insists on burying him there, citing strong cultural traditions of burial in the fatherland as a matter of honour. Thus, the core conflict is ignited by the dispute between the communities of Amabiri and Angiama over where Oweibi should be buried.

Climax

The play attains its height when the Amabiri people arrive at Angiama, prepared for confrontation, only to discover that Oweibi has been buried. The Angiama people in a philosophical move to prevent bloodshed and war buried him ahead of the scheduled date.

Falling Action

Actions in the play begin to dwindle, as the Amabiri emissaries are frustrated and threaten violence, but the Angiama people, led by Pifa sue for peace, emphasizing the value of human life over unbearable tradition.

Resolution

The play's resolution is achieved when the Amabiri people reluctantly accept the peaceful resolution proposed by Angiama, stretching out hands of peace, thus, concluding with a victory for the more progressive, humane perspective.

Plot/Structure Development of *The Last Rites* by John Suofe.

Exposition

The Last Rites by John Suofe is set in 21st century, of the Niger Delta Region of Nigeria, with

high stakes of throwing elaborate/extravagance ceremonies for the dead, against when those characters were alive. The play is structured into situations; eight in number. The plot is scattered around between Debe-ama town in the Niger Delta and Lagos in the South-West. However, it formally opens with Izon-oweï and Braye (husband and wife) engaged in their trade of preparing thatch for sale which is their livelihood in the middle of the night, all in a bid to train their first son, Kosu-oweï's education.

Dramatic Conflict and Rising Action

Conflict erupts in the play when Kosu-oweï, the first son to both Izon-oweï and Braye, after his parents suffered to train him to be a University graduate, and fortunately secures appointment in Lagos and begins to live a big glamorous life without recourse to his parents welfare, and his only younger brother's education.

Climax

The play attains its climax when because of poverty and financial indebtedness of the duo, Izon-oweï and Braye; As a result, Izon-oweï borrowed some money and sent his wife, Braye to Lagos to meet their son for money, and he gives a meager sum that cannot even cover up the debts, yet witnesses their son feeding two huge dogs with fabulous amount.

Falling Action

Actions in the play begin to fall, when Izon-Oweï, unsatisfied with the money he receives from the son through his wife, thus, compelling him embark on a similar journey himself for enhanced package, and eventually returns home to witness the death of Olotu, their neighbor who was also in the same shoe with them, but, his son throws a lavish burial for a man who died out of penury and poverty.

Resolution

Events in the play comes to a close, when both Kosu-Oweï's parents, Izon-Oweï and Braye participated in the burial rites of Olotu who died in poverty and penury, yet saw how elaborate and extravagant a ceremony his son throws on the dead calling it, The last rites. Thus, both husband and wife plotted and devised a deceptive strategy of death of the father, Izon-Oweï and passed the information to their son, Kosu-Oweï. This news alone goes to inspire the son and declared that, he must give the "last rites" to his father. Hear him as he replies his mother who goes to pass the information.

KOSU-OWEI

(*Bringing out an envelope, gives mother*). Mama, no problems.

Take this. Use it to deposit Papa in any nearby Morgue. It contains one hundred thousand naira (₦100,000.00) only. I want to see my father back before he goes to meet his ancestors finally. And I must arrange for a befitting "last rites". (p.82)

Thus, the deception worked and Izon-Oweï and Braye are seen building mansions, swim in money and later lived comfortably.

We have gone a long way in trying to analyze the plot structure development of the selected

works for this study. A critical examination reveals that, the two plays explore the themes of honour, pride, identity, extravagance, territoriality and deception in the face of death.

However, all in all, both Ayakoroma and Suofe's plays examine the moral and ethical dilemmas society face as they navigate the complex intersection of honour and death, while the study seeking to uncover the differing perspectives on honour and death presented in the two books and their implications for the characters and the society they inhabit.

Dimensions of Honour in Barclays Ayakoroma's *A Matter Of Honour*.

As earlier discussed in the preceding pages, death and burial are intrinsically interwoven. The two form a continuous process across human cultures and history. It is a common belief that; death of any type necessitates burial. Therefore, one dimension of honour accorded the dead man in Barclays' Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour* is;
Cultural/Traditional Honour

It is a general phenomenon that, when a man dies, his body has to return to mother earth. And that is the first honour the dead receives from his family, community and society. It would be against natural order and traditional customs that, a man dies and his body be kept to rot away. There would be no honour and dignity for the family and equally the deceased. However, how that honour is given is the problem. In traditional Izon society, because of its patriarchal view, burial honour of the dead should be in the fatherland. This will show a deep-seated marker of honour and belonging, even if he lived and died elsewhere, thereby, equally allowing peaceful entry of the deceased spirit in to yonder world. This could be affirmed from the words of Egberi in the play, when he broke the news of the death of Oweibi at the marriage ground and when asked whether, he was sick. Egberi replies with the following words:

EGBERI

I was in Angiama when the death news came.
I can only tell you that he is dead. For now it
is not important whether he was sick and for
how long. What should concern us is the matter of honour (p.6)

The above foregrounds the fact why both communities of Amabiri and Angiama were prepared to bury Oweibi, knowing the honour attached to the dead in society.

Another dimension of honour accorded the dead in *A Matter of Honour* by Barclays Ayakoroma is that of; Personal Honour.

This is going to reflect the deceased standing in the society, whether, he lived well among his people or not. His past life always speaks for the type of honour he gets.

ABERE

Then you forget that our son sired Oweibi.

ABIDE

We thank you for that.

ABERE

And as our son, tradition demands that we be
responsible for the interment of his bones.

ABIDE

You lie! You people never cared for him. You should be ashamed that you are coming to ask for the body of a dead person whom you never cared for when he was alive.

ABERE

We are not ashamed for respecting tradition. Tradition is tradition. We want the body of our son!

ABIDE

You will not have it. We have made... because you've never been part of his life (p.21).

In addition, there is also the honour of territorial consciousness which stems from the ancestral or cultural ethos, that the dead buried in his fatherland to register a significant marker of honour and identity with his people.

Furthermore, there is the nationalistic/political Honour given to the dead. This honour reflects the community's pride and territorial right to the corpse. Barclays Ayakoroma in his play; *A Matter of Honour* reveals that, in Izonland, in the face of death and burials, honour is tied to defending one's ancestral land asserting dominance. Barclays introduces this singular honour as the one leading to the conflict over the corpse of Oweibi. This is a symbol of territorial rights.

Finally, the Honour of morality is also exercised in the play as to give peace and eternal rest to the dead. In the play; Barclays critiques the violence these disputes cause, showing that true honour must accommodate peace, human dignity and wisdom, as voiced by characters like Pifa, representing the playwright's view. Ultimately, the play argues for a broader, more inclusive honour that prioritizes peace and human life over destructive territorial disputes, challenging the absolute nature of tradition.

Death and Dimension of honour in *The Last Rites* by John Suofe.

Like Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour* where burial is an integral part of the dead, John Suofe's *The Last Rites* also treats burial as the chief-most dimension of honour accorded the dead. It is a common phenomenon in most societies that, when someone dies, it behooves on that family or community to bury their dead. For it is the only honour and dignity you have given the dead to rest well in eternity or in the ancestral world. Thus, when a dead person is kept to rot away, it is against natural order which even attracts some spiritual curses in differing societies. The importance of burying the dead as an honour is intoned in the dialogue between Braye and her husband, Izon-owe below.

BRAYE

My husband, wonders they say, shall never end. Is not a small thing o! When the son was informed of the death, he quickly responded that, his father should be deposited in the Morgue pending when he might have concluded necessary arrangements for

a befitting burial.

IZON-OWEI

(*Embittered*) Deposit where... in the Morgue? Do I hear you well or are my ears started failing me? So he said this? God have mercy on him. Why did he not also desert the dead man as he did in the life time? (Oborii mbehee). Didn't he know...? Now because he is dead, there is money? I see God... (p.54)

This dialogue between the duos explains clearly that it is a must that, the dead be buried, no matter how long you delay it by way of civilization. For it is the final honour you are according the dead.

Yet, another dimension of honour John Suofe treats in his play; *The Last Rites* which he finds his society is indulging and he lampoons is that of;

Extravagant funerary ceremonies. We have said that, the dead is always buried, therefore the burials does not warrant that, until you bury your dead with elaborate ceremonies or lavishness, before one could understand that you are honouring the dead. The saddest part is that, when these characters were alive, the so called children or family people shirk their parental responsibility of upkeep. Worst again, these parents perhaps died as a result of penury and poverty. But, at the mention of their death, every child wants to honour their dead in an elaborate way, thus, spending extravagantly in the name of according the "last rites", which is a dimension of honour in the face of the dead. The honour of elaborate ceremonies/extravagance according to the dead in John Suofe's *The Last Rites* could be better explained with the dialogue between Braye and Izon-owei when, the later returns from his son's place in Lagos and greeted with the news of the death of Olotu, their neighbor and later the burial which they participated.

IZON-OWEI

So, when did the son say he would bury his father?

BRAYE

January 10th. That is two months from now. Perhaps, when the new house he has started building will be completed.

IZON-OWEI

O, he has even started a new building? Poor Olotu! May his Soul rest in peace. So, this is what is going to happen to us too? Never... A house that the father is supposed to inherit at living, will only be occupied in death. When he was alive, no son, but suffering, penury and poverty.

BRAYE

That is just one thing. According to the burial arrangements, King Robert Ebizimor, Master Pere-ama, Gen. Alaska alongside musical sets will make the night. You see! It is a lot of money involved. He has even bought one giant size cow for the occasion.

Izon-owe, my husband, I think, we must attend this burial
come the date. After all... (PP.56-58).

Then, of course, another “make believe” honour burial scene could also be affirmed from the deceptive death of Izon-owe, Kosu-owe's father. When both husband and wife participated in the burial ceremony of Olotu, their close neighbor and witnessed the extravagance display of wealth by the son. Izon-owe too deceptively died, and when the news got to Kosu-owe, the first son. He too planned an elaborate/ extravagance ceremony to accord his father, “The Last Rites”. Building of houses, buying of cows, and engaging of live bands such as King Robert, Pere-ama etc were contained in the burial program. But, the wisdom of his parents outwit him and they ended up accorded the last rites while alive, for all the monies expended in the name of buying the father was diverted to building modern houses for themselves and living buoyantly.

Summary of Findings

The selected plays for this study here address death as not merely a biological end but social, cultural, and political event that tests the values of honour, pride, humanity and economic frugality with a community, thus, while Ayakoroma specifically advocating for a more inclusive, less violent, and gender-equitable approach to funerals, John equivocally or strongly advocates for an economic frugality approach. Thus, the findings of this study revealed the invaluable role of burial as the ultimate expression of family/communal Honour to the dead. For instance, the two selected plays studied here analyzed similar themes of death and dignity, which compels the characters to perform varied forms of “honour” on the dead.

This study also unveils issues of death as a site of conflict, territorial consciousness, and extravagant funerary ceremonies. (E.g.) The conflict that revolves around a dispute over the right of possession of a corpse, where burial acts as a testament to territorial supremacy and ancestral belongings.

This study further revealed issues of redefining honour and peace. For example; In *A Matter of Honour*, Ayakoroma challenges the tradition of valuing war over peace, thus, offering a “voice of reason” that prioritizes human dignity over rigid, violent customs.

It is also found that, there is the victory of burial feminism. It would be recalled that, the research identifies a feminist victory in the play by Ayakoroma, as the deceased (Oweibi) is ultimately buried in his motherland (Angiama) defying traditional male dominated burial, or patriarchal oppression.

In addition, this study also reveals Rites as reaffirmation of cultural identity and nationalism. For instance, the two selected plays uses Izon cultural settings, proverbs and bilingualism to explore how cultural rites, pride, identity, and nationalism are reaffirmed whereby intertwined with the dead body. With the performance of, or struggle over, cast rites (funeral ceremonies) is crucial for validating the social and humanity of the deceased.

Finally, this study also unveils issues of reconciliation of the Dead and Living. It would be recalled that, all burials in Izon tradition requires rituals. These rituals serve as a mechanism to transform the deceased into an ancestor, bringing comfort to the living and ensuring the

deceased's honorable entry into the afterlife.

Contribution to Knowledge

***Understanding funeral practices as political strategy**

For example; In Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour*, the playwright portrays the struggle over a corpse as a “dialectics of burial and territoriality”, where funerals are not merely personal grief events, but battles for communal pride, identity, prestige, and territorial supremacy. It highlights how the “right to bury” becomes a tool of social recognition or subjugation.

***Redefining “Honour” within Izon worldview**

In both, *A Matter of Honour* and *The Last Rites*, the playwrights redefine honour from blind adherence to strict patriarchal tradition, towards humanizing unbendable tradition on one side, and of course, wasteful/senseless spending on the other side to prioritize peace, dignity, and frugality. For the playwrights, it will demonstrate that, true honour in burial involves acknowledging where a person actually lived and was supported, rather than just where they were born or exercising economic frugality for the living to forge ahead in life. After all, what is important is; the dead had been buried, not minding a bogus ceremony, thus calling for the prioritization of the living over the dead.

***Theatricalizing Cultural Aesthetics**

This study contributes to scholarship by analyzing how Ayakoroma and John use “African Lingo-cultural elements” (native proverbs rhetorics, and metaphors) to translate Izon cultural experiences into English medium. This provides an analysis of how drama captures the existential reality of the Izon (Niger Delta).

***Another contribution to knowledge of this study is the application of “Funeral Feminism”.**

That is gendered ownership of corpses. This paper contributes to the discourse on feminism in African literature by introducing the concept of “burial Feminism” or “funeral feminism”. It highlights how women's roles in bringing up children are used to challenge the patriarchal claim to burial rights.

Lastly, there is the knowledge of comparative analysis of African existential realities. By pairing Ayakoroma with Suofe, the paper allows for a comparative analysis of how different playwrights handle the theme of the “last rites” and its implications for societal dignity.

The study further recommends future research on comparative studies in death and honour, by comparing these works with other Nigerian plays focusing on death. (e.g.) Soyinka's “Death and the Kings Horseman”, focusing on how different cultures in Nigeria navigates the intersection of mortality, honour, and duty.

Recommendations

This study recommends the re-evaluation of cultural traditions on burial and honour, such as communities re-examining rigid traditions regarding burial rites that privileges paternal heritage over the actual place of residence (maternal or chosen land) as these often lead to avoidable conflicts.

It further recommends; re-evaluating extravagant funerary ceremonies. Society should reconsider the economic and social strain of elaborate burial ceremonies, which often leads to wasteful expenditure and conflicts in the Niger Delta.

This study again recommends the reconciling of tradition with modern reality. Societies should encourage traditional institutions to evolve, specifically by making rigid burial customs (e.g.) fatherland-only burial) more flexible to accommodate modern lived experiences, as seen in the resolution of Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour*.

This study still recommends dialogue over violence. By this, community leaders and families are required to adopt dialogue and peaceful mediation over conflict and “war-drumming” regarding the burial rites of the deceased.

Finally, this study recommends future research on comparative studies in death and honour, by comparing these works with other Nigerian plays focusing on death. (e.g.) Soyinka's *Death and the Kings Horseman*, focusing on how, different cultures in Nigeria navigates the intersection of mortality, honour, and duty.

Conclusion

Both Ayakoroma's *A Matter of Honour* and Suofe's *The Last Rites* explore the themes of death and the dimensions of honour in the context of rich cultural traditions and social structures. Through the narratives of their characters, they present a complex and thought-provoking examination of the different ways in which honour is perceived and pursued in the Niger Delta Region in particular and the Nigerian society in general. Ultimately, these stories illuminate the profound impact that notions of honour, dignity, and pride can have on individuals and communities, inviting readers to reflect on the significance of values such as integrity, respect and loyalty in the face of life's most profound mysteries and challenges. The two playwrights, as students of culture, one clearly disagrees with the cultural position that, a dead man in Izon land should be buried in his fatherland while, the later also protest about elaborate ceremonies/extravagance in burying the dead. Thus, both playwrights, through traditional African burial rites, critique the rigid, pride-driven conception of honour, but favoring communal harmony, human dignity and economic frugality instead.

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